

A Report on English Learning Strategies

Weinan Normal University

Introduction

English has become an indispensable tool in today's globalized world, especially for China's reform and opening up. As a mathematics education major at Weinan Normal University, I realize that mastering English is essential not only for my academic growth but also for my future career as a teacher. However, learning English is not an easy task — it requires effective strategies and consistent effort. To explore which learning strategies are most effective, I interviewed three classmates from different majors and analyzed their approaches to English learning. This report presents my findings, evaluates the strategies they adopted, and proposes a plan to improve my own learning.

Part I People I Interviewed

I interviewed the following three classmates, each with a different major and different strengths in English learning:

1. Li Xiaomei — English Major, Junior

Li Xiaomei is an English major who has passed TEM-4 with excellent grades. She spends about two hours every day on English and has developed a systematic learning routine.

2. Wang Hao — Computer Science Major, Sophomore

Wang Hao is a computer science student who learned English mainly out of practical need — reading programming documentation and watching technical tutorials in English. His CET-4 score is 560.

3. Zhang Yiting — Chinese Language and Literature Major, Senior

Zhang Yiting is preparing for the postgraduate entrance examination, which includes an English section. She has passed CET-6 and focuses on improving her reading and writing skills.

Part II Strategies They Adopted

Li Xiaomei's Strategies:

- **Listening to English songs and watching English movies:** She watches at least one English movie per week without subtitles and listens to BBC podcasts during her

commute. She said, "This helps me get used to the natural rhythm and intonation of English."

- **Using English-English dictionaries:** She exclusively uses the Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English. "Looking up words in an English-English dictionary forces me to think in English instead of translating word by word," she explained.
- **Keeping a dedicated vocabulary notebook:** She organizes words by topic (e.g., education, environment, technology) and reviews them every Sunday using the spaced repetition method.
- **Connecting with English speakers online:** She has been exchanging emails with a pen pal from the UK for over a year. This practice improves both her writing and cultural awareness.

Wang Hao's Strategies:

- **Spending one hour per day reading English articles:** He reads technical articles from GitHub, Stack Overflow, and TechCrunch. "Since I'm studying computer science, most documentation is in English. Reading it daily is both a language exercise and a professional requirement," he said.
- **Paying close attention to new vocabulary while reading:** He highlights unfamiliar words and adds them to a digital word list on his phone, reviewing them during spare moments like waiting in line or taking the bus.
- **Watching English tech tutorials with subtitles:** He watches YouTube programming tutorials with English subtitles on, then rewatches them with subtitles off to test his listening comprehension.

Zhang Yiting's Strategies:

- **Reading English articles for 30 minutes daily:** She focuses on reading materials from The Economist and China Daily, which she finds particularly helpful for the reading comprehension section of the postgraduate entrance exam.
- **Keeping a notebook for new words and idioms:** She writes each new word with its definition, an example sentence, and a Chinese translation. She reviews the notebook every morning before class.
- **Practicing writing English essays weekly:** She writes one argumentative essay per week on current social topics and asks her English teacher for feedback. "Writing forces me to organize my thoughts logically and use new vocabulary actively," she noted.

Part III My Evaluation of Their Strategies

After comparing the strategies my three classmates use, I have the following evaluations:

1. Combining Input and Output Is Most Effective

Li Xiaomei's approach stands out because she combines all four language skills — listening, speaking, reading, and writing. Watching movies trains her listening, emailing her pen pal practices writing and speaking, and reading broadens her vocabulary. This balanced approach ensures comprehensive improvement rather than excelling in only one area.

2. Connecting Learning to Personal Interests Boosts Motivation

Wang Hao's strategy is remarkable because he ties English learning directly to his major. Reading programming documentation in English is not a burden for him — it is a daily necessity. When learning serves a practical purpose, motivation comes naturally. This is a strategy I should adopt in my own field of mathematics education.

3. Consistency Matters More Than Intensity

All three classmates emphasized the importance of daily practice, even if it is just 30 minutes. Zhang Yiting's routine of reading for half an hour every day may seem modest, but the cumulative effect over months and years is enormous. This confirms what language learning research has long shown: regular, short sessions are more effective than occasional marathon study sessions.

4. Using English-English Dictionaries Builds Thinking in English

Li Xiaomei's habit of using English-English dictionaries is particularly valuable. Although it is slower at first, it trains the brain to think directly in English rather than relying on translation. This is a strategy I personally find challenging but recognize as essential for advanced proficiency.

Part IV A Plan to Improve My Own Learning Strategies

Based on the strategies I have learned from my classmates, I have developed the following plan to improve my English learning:

1. Daily Reading Habit

I will spend 30 minutes every morning reading English articles related to education and mathematics, such as those from Education Week or math education journals. This connects language learning with my major, following Wang Hao's approach.

2. Vocabulary Notebook with Spaced Repetition

Inspired by both Li Xiaomei and Zhang Yiting, I will keep a dedicated vocabulary notebook. I will organize words by topic and review them on a weekly basis using the spaced repetition technique — reviewing new words after one day, three days, one week, and two weeks.

3. Switch to English-English Dictionaries

I will follow Li Xiaomei's advice and start using the Longman or Oxford Learner's Dictionary for new words. Although it may be slower initially, I believe this habit will help me think in English and improve my comprehension over time.

4. Weekly English Writing Practice

Following Zhang Yiting's example, I will write one short English essay per week. Topics could include my reflections on teaching practice, summaries of mathematics education theories, or opinions on current events. I will ask my English teacher or use online tools for feedback.

5. English Entertainment Integration

To make learning more enjoyable, I will watch one English movie or TV episode per week and listen to English podcasts during my daily commute. This will improve my listening skills while keeping the learning process relaxing and fun, similar to Li Xiaomei's approach.

Conclusion

Through interviewing my three classmates, I have gained a deeper understanding of effective English learning strategies. Each person's approach reflects their unique background, major, and goals, but common themes emerge: consistency, combining multiple skills, connecting learning to personal interests, and using tools like English-English dictionaries and vocabulary notebooks. I have also developed a concrete plan to improve my own English learning, incorporating the best practices I observed. I believe that with these strategies and persistent effort, I will not only pass the required English examinations but also develop the language proficiency needed for my future career as a mathematics educator.